OPINION | GEOPOLITICS

The Wrong Denominator: Netanyahu's “Hoax” Answer and the Arithmetic of Accountability

A headcount of offenders is not a measure of state control. Enforcement data is.

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Asked by CNN's Jim Sciutto this week whether his government had lost control of settler violence in the West Bank, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said it was “a tremendous hoax.” Within seconds he softened the claim. He told Sciutto he cannot accept a vigilante, that he had put the Shin Bet on the problem, and that the culprits number about “150, 200” juvenile delinquents. The following day, Standing Together, a Jewish-Arab movement, said its activists, who were accompanying Palestinian farmers near Bethlehem ahead of the olive harvest, were attacked with clubs, pepper spray and stones.

What he actually said

Fairness first. Netanyahu condemned vigilantism in plain terms, and he acknowledged what critics say he denies: that these men cut down olive trees, throw stones, and have “claimed the lives of Palestinians.” He then argued that the debate lacks proportion. He cited the killing of an Israeli-French father of six and the attack on the Israeli ambassador's son, and said that equating such violence with settler crime creates a false symmetry.

That is a serious point, and it deserves a serious reply. Israeli victims of terrorism are real, their families are real, and one set of crimes does not cancel another. Anyone who uses settler violence to wave away Israeli grief commits the same error in reverse.

Where the argument slips

The trouble is the measure. Netanyahu answered a question about state capacity with figures about perpetrators. Sciutto's question was whether the government is in control. “Only 150 to 200 people” is a claim about the size of a group. It says nothing about how many incidents they commit, how many are arrested, indicted or convicted, or whether the security forces protect the villagers in the field. A small group acting repeatedly and rarely facing consequences is not a reassuring statistic. It is a description of impunity.

As an actuary, I would call this using the wrong denominator. The headcount of offenders is one number. The incident rate, the enforcement rate and the share of victims who can reach their land safely are the numbers that answer the question asked. None of them appeared in the exchange,

and I could not find them in the coverage I reviewed. The 150-to-200 figure was offered as a claim and was not tested in the clip. Independent data from UN agencies and Israeli rights groups can test it, and editors should ask for them.

The “hoax” label also sits awkwardly beside his own admissions. If vigilantes are cutting down trees, killing people and attacking civilians, the phenomenon is not invented. What he disputes is its scale, its political meaning and the comparison with Hamas-linked attacks. Those are arguments, and they should be made as arguments rather than labelled a hoax.

The principle beneath the quarrel

A basic principle runs through most legal traditions: whoever exercises effective control over a territory bears the duty to protect the people in it, and that duty is not discharged, reduced or offset by what others do elsewhere. Israeli governments dispute the framing of the West Bank's status. But “who is responsible for these villagers' safety today?” does not depend on that dispute, and a rare public rebuke after a recent settler attack injured Israeli forces, reported by AFP, suggests even Israeli institutions can see the problem.

What would help

1. **Publish enforcement data:** arrests, indictments, convictions and protective deployments around the olive harvest. Numbers are the quickest way to turn a dispute over labels into a dispute over facts.
2. **Allow independent monitoring** of the harvest, including the “protective presence” of Israeli and international volunteers, and protect them as well.
3. **For those of us in the media, put the data in the question.** “Has your government lost control?” can be answered with a speech. “How many have been charged this year?” cannot.

The Israeli families who mourn and the Palestinian families who fear are making the same demand, in different languages: that someone with power act, and be counted when they do.

Bilal Ahmed Khan is an independent investigative journalist and data actuary working in political sciences, based in Pakistan. This piece draws on the circulated excerpt of Prime Minister Netanyahu's CNN interview with Jim Sciutto, and on reporting by the Jerusalem Post, Al-Monitor and AFP. Views are the author's own.